



MARCH – THE SEASON BEGINS

March is often the month beekeepers have been waiting for.

After months of monitoring food stores, protecting colonies from winter weather and resisting the temptation to interfere, signs of spring finally begin to appear. The days become noticeably longer, temperatures gradually improve and colonies begin preparing for a season of growth.

For many beekeepers, March feels like the true beginning of the beekeeping year.

However, March is also a month that demands patience. Warm afternoons can quickly be followed by frosty nights, strong winds and prolonged rain. Colonies may be expanding, but they remain vulnerable.

The challenge throughout March is supporting colony development without pushing bees ahead of the weather.

WEATHER, TEMPERATURE & SEASONAL TIMING (MARCH IN THE UK)

March can be one of the most unpredictable months of the year.

Some days feel remarkably spring-like, while others remind us that winter is not yet finished. Local conditions often vary significantly, and what is possible in one part of the country may not be appropriate elsewhere.

As temperatures improve, bees begin flying more regularly and forage becomes increasingly available. Early pollen sources such as willow, crocus, hazel and dandelion begin supporting brood rearing and colony expansion.

Despite this, periods of poor weather can still leave colonies confined for days at a time.

March should always be approached with flexibility rather than fixed dates.

REALITY CHECK: A warm weekend does not mean spring has fully arrived.

WHAT YOUR BEES ARE DOING

The colony is now transitioning from winter survival to spring development.

Queens begin increasing egg laying and brood nests expand steadily. As brood production increases, so does the colony's demand for food and resources.

Workers are increasingly focused on collecting pollen and nectar whenever weather permits. Pollen is particularly important at this stage as it provides the protein needed for brood rearing.



The colony is attempting to build momentum for the season ahead.

Everything that happens during March influences colony strength later in spring.

WHAT YOU SHOULD BE DOING IN MARCH

March is primarily a month of assessment.

The objective is not to perform major manipulations but to understand how colonies have emerged from winter.

Questions every beekeeper should be asking include:

Is the colony queenright?

Does it have adequate stores?

Is brood present?

Does the brood appear healthy?

Is additional space likely to be required soon?

The answers to these questions help shape management decisions throughout spring.

PRACTICAL RULE: March is a month for gathering information rather than making major changes.

FOOD STORES – STILL THE PRIORITY

Many colony losses occur during late winter and early spring rather than during the coldest part of the year.

As brood production increases, food consumption rises dramatically. Colonies that appeared comfortable in January can become surprisingly light by March.

Regular hefting remains important.

Colonies should be assessed carefully and emergency feed provided where necessary.

Fondant often remains the safest option during colder periods, while syrup may become appropriate later if weather conditions allow.

Never assume that active flying means adequate food reserves.

REALITY CHECK: The colony that survives winter can still starve in March.



THE FIRST SPRING INSPECTION

March is often when beekeepers begin considering their first full inspection of the year.

However, timing is critical.

The first inspection should only take place when conditions are suitable. A calm, dry day with temperatures around 12°C or above is often used as a guideline, but local conditions and colony behaviour should always be considered.

The purpose of the first inspection is simple:

Confirm the colony is alive, queenright, healthy and has sufficient food.

This is not the time for lengthy inspections or unnecessary disturbance.

Work methodically and minimise the amount of time brood remains exposed.

BROOD ASSESSMENT AND COLONY HEALTH

One of the most valuable aspects of the first spring inspection is the opportunity to assess brood quality.

A healthy brood nest should generally show a logical progression from eggs to larvae and sealed brood.

Brood patterns do not need to be perfect, particularly in early spring, but they should provide reassurance that the queen is functioning effectively.

March is also an important time to remain alert for signs of disease.

Any unusual brood patterns, discoloured larvae, unusual smells or abnormal adult bee behaviour should be investigated further.

Early identification provides the greatest opportunity for successful intervention.

SPACE MANAGEMENT AND EARLY SUPERING

Strong colonies can develop surprisingly quickly once favourable weather arrives.

While many colonies will not require additional space immediately, March is the month when beekeepers should begin thinking ahead.

A colony that occupies most brood frames and continues expanding may soon require additional room.

In some locations, strong colonies may even justify an early super if significant nectar flows are expected.



March is less about adding space and more about preparing for when it becomes necessary.

PRACTICAL RULE: It is easier to stay ahead of colony growth than it is to catch up with it.

APIARY AND EQUIPMENT PREPARATION

March is one of the best months to prepare for the season ahead.

Equipment that seemed unnecessary during winter will soon become essential.

Frames should be assembled, foundation fitted, supers prepared and spare equipment organised.

Apiaries should also be checked for winter damage.

Hive stands, roofs, straps and water sources all deserve attention before colony activity increases significantly.

The beekeepers who are prepared in March are often the beekeepers who remain calm during May.

PLANNING FOR SWARM SEASON

Swarm season may still feel distant, but March is the ideal time to prepare.

Strong colonies can expand rapidly once temperatures improve.

Spare brood boxes, nucleus equipment and swarm control plans should all be considered now.

Good preparation prevents rushed decisions later.

The colonies that become crowded in April and May often started their rapid expansion during March.

RECORD KEEPING

March marks the return of meaningful record keeping after winter.

Inspection notes should include:

Food reserves.

Brood development.

Queen status.

Temperament.

Signs of disease.



BeezKnees – March Apiary Master Guide

March apiary master guide for cool, temperate UK climate

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Equipment requirements.

These records become increasingly valuable as colony development accelerates throughout spring.

Accurate records help identify trends and support better decision-making later in the season.

LOOKING TOWARDS APRIL

By the end of March, many colonies are noticeably stronger than they were only a few weeks earlier.

Brood nests are larger.

Pollen collection is increasing.

Forage becomes more reliable.

The pace of colony development begins to accelerate.

April brings more regular inspections, stronger colony growth and the first real signs of swarm preparation.

The foundations for all of that are established during March.

MARCH TAKEAWAY

March is the month when the beekeeping year truly begins.

Colonies are moving beyond winter survival and beginning the process of spring expansion.

The beekeeper's role is to assess colony condition, monitor food reserves, prepare equipment and support healthy development without rushing the season.

Patience remains important.

Preparation becomes essential.

The colonies managed carefully in March are often the colonies that thrive throughout spring and summer.

REALITY CHECK: March is not about forcing colonies forward. It is about giving them the best possible start to the season ahead.